Independent Evidentiary and Methodological Audit: Enterprise AI Customer Service Agent Market Report

Executive Audit Summary and Epistemic Framework

An independent evidentiary audit of the market research report on enterprise artificial intelligence (AI) customer service agents exposes systemic methodological vulnerabilities across vendor pricing comparisons, capability assessments, macroeconomic forecasts, and customer return-on-investment (ROI) case studies. While the underlying literature accurately reflects the structural transition of the customer support software sector from seat-based subscriptions to consumption- and outcome-based monetization between September 2024 and October 2026[1], the baseline analysis frequently conflates vendor promotional assertions with audited operational metrics, relies on superseded rate cards, and treats unverified third-party pricing estimates as established market facts[5].

To establish analytical rigor and prevent flawed procurement or investment decisions, this review enforces a strict four-tier epistemic taxonomy paired with four explicit evidentiary confidence ratings across all evaluated assertions. Within the epistemic taxonomy, **Verified Facts** encompass objective data points directly corroborated by primary vendor rate cards, current technical documentation as of October 2026, regulatory compliance registries, or peer-reviewed empirical research[1]. **User-Reported Experiences** capture qualitative observations, billing complaints, and small-sample manual ticket audits sourced from public review aggregators such as G2, Capterra, and TrustRadius, as well as community forums including Reddit and the Intercom Community[12]; while these accounts reflect genuine operational friction, they are subject to self-selection bias and cannot be extrapolated as population-level statistical benchmarks without primary sampling. **Analyst Inferences** represent deductive conclusions derived by modeling published unit economics—such as calculating break-even thresholds between per-action and per-resolution meters—or by synthesizing secondary venture intelligence estimates[1]. Finally, **Hypotheses** denote testable propositions regarding causal mechanisms—such as the premise that knowledge base structuring governs autonomous deflection ceilings or that outcome-based billing systematically incentivizes premature conversation closure—that require controlled primary investigation to confirm[12]. Each evaluated claim is further assigned a confidence rating of **High** (supported by authoritative, direct evidence), **Medium** (supported by credible but incomplete evidence), **Low** (supported by indirect evidence or a limited number of observations), or **Unverified** (insufficient evidence).

Comprehensive Twelve-Point Diagnostic Challenge

1. Material Factual Claims Lacking Direct Supporting Sources

A granular inspection of the collected literature reveals numerous material assertions that

circulate across secondary commentary without a traceable primary source. In evaluating **Sierra AI**, multiple secondary analyses state as fact that the company enforces an annual platform license floor of $150,000 to $750,000+, charges one-time implementation and setup fees between $50,000 and $200,000 across a three-to-seven-month deployment window, and bills between $1.00 and $2.50 per autonomous resolution[7]. However, those same secondary articles explicitly concede that Sierra publishes no pricing page, calculator, or rate card, and has never confirmed any of these figures publicly[7]. Similarly, claims that enterprise clients such as SiriusXM, Sonos, and ADT achieve "70%+ resolution rates" on Sierra[8], or that competitor **Decagon** charges a "~$50K platform fee + usage" with a three-to-six-week implementation timeline[7], appear strictly as unsourced assertions embedded in competitor comparison tables.

Even within extensively documented vendor ecosystems, critical primary source gaps persist. For **Salesforce Agentforce**, the September 2026 packaging overhaul replaced the legacy lineup with the Core ($195/user/month$), $Advanced$(395/user/month), and Max ($550/user/month) Service Cloud editions[1]. While the official Service Cloud pricing page confirms that the Max edition includes 2.75 million Flex Credits annually, the official pricing page omits credit allocations for Core and Advanced; the claims that Core includes 500,000 Flex Credits and Advanced includes 1 million Flex Credits rest solely on secondary citations of Salesforce blog posts and newsroom announcements rather than binding rate-card schedules[1]. Furthermore, a sensational claim appearing in Reddit sidebar feeds asserting that *"Salesforce acquires AI customer service platform Fin for $3.6 billion"*[15]—and echoed in a secondary review warning buyers against *"committing to a platform mid-acquisition"*[12]—lacks any corroboration from official corporate filings or financial newsrooms, directly contradicting contemporaneous October 2026 market analyses that evaluate Intercom Fin and Salesforce Agentforce as independent competitors[2].

2. Claims Based Exclusively on Vendor Marketing

The baseline report incorporates multiple performance metrics derived entirely from unverified vendor self-reporting and promotional case studies. **Salesforce** asserts that its internal Agentforce deployment managed 1.5 million support requests on its help portal over one year without human intervention in most instances, and that **OpenTable** resolved 73% of restaurant web queries within three weeks of launch, representing a 50% improvement over legacy tools[21]. **Intercom** markets Fin AI as having resolved over 40 million conversations at a 71% to 76% resolution rate[11], while simultaneously utilizing its own content marketing apparatus (fin.ai/learn/sierra-ai-pricing) to frame competitor Sierra AI as prohibitively expensive and slow to deploy[7].

Smaller and competing contact center vendors exhibit identical promotional inflation. **Enjo.ai** claims its virtual agents consistently deliver "60%+ auto-resolution rates" with customer satisfaction (CSAT) scores "exceeding 90% even for technical support scenarios," alongside "40% productivity improvements" from agent augmentation tools[5]. **Five9** asserts that its Intelligent CX Platform increases agent productivity "by two times"[22]. **Sprinklr** reports that logistics provider **Aramex** achieved "99% bot containment, deflecting 20.2 million cases a year

and saving roughly 1.3 million agent hours annually"[6]. **Freshworks** claims that customer interaction costs dropped 68% after AI implementation, declining from $4.60 to $1.45 per contact[23]. Finally, at Sierra Summit 2026, **Sierra AI** leadership claimed that *"a year ago almost all code was written by hand, and today it's mostly written by AI,"* while asserting that its Agent OS delivers a tokenomics cost basis superior to any in-house enterprise build[24]. None of these figures have undergone independent third-party audit, and none disclose the underlying denominator definitions, such as whether abandoned sessions or frustrated repeat contacts within 24 hours were counted as successful containment.

3. Claims Based on Outdated Product Documentation

Rapid pricing and architectural iterations between September 2024 and October 2026 have rendered much of the secondary literature obsolete. The most prominent error in the baseline market analysis is the characterization of **Salesforce Agentforce** as a flat "$2.00 per conversation" platform—a figure still cited in Intercom Fin's 2026 competitive comparison table to project a $100,000 monthly (1,200,000 annual) usage bill for 50,000 monthly conversations[7]. In reality, the $2.00 per conversation meter launched in September 2024 is now a legacy contract structure restricted to existing customers and hidden from new buyers[1]. As of October 2026, Agentforce pricing operates across three modernized pillars. The first pillar, **Flex Credits**, was introduced in May 2025 at $500 per 100,000 credits, consuming 20 credits (0.10) per standard text action in production, 16 credits (0.08) in sandbox environments, and 30 credits (0.15) per voice action, with no credit rollover and no charges for escalations, variable updates, or topic transitions[1]. The second pillar, **Outcome-Based Resolution and Lead Meters**, became available in July 2026, charging 400 Flex Credits ($2.00) per billable **Help Agent** self-service resolution (which bundles actions and Data 360 queries while leaving unresolved sessions free, subject to 2-hour and 10-minute session caps) and 400 Flex Credits ($2.00) per **Buyer Engagement Agent** "Lead Worked"[1]. The third pillar encompasses **Employee Licensing and Realigned Editions**, introduced between June 2025 and September 2026, offering metered employee access at $5/user/month (requiring Flex Credits), unmetered employee usage add-ons at $125/user/month (150/user/month for Industries), and the September 2026 replacement of legacy Service Cloud tiers and "Agentforce 1 Editions" with Core (195), $Advanced$ (395), and Max ($550) editions[1]. Furthermore, references to "Salesforce Data Cloud" or "Service Cloud Einstein" reflect legacy branding prior to the October 2025 rebranding of Data Cloud to **Data 360** and the transition to Agentforce[1].

Outdated documentation also distorts the evaluation of **Intercom** and **Zendesk**. References to an always-free Intercom "Starter plan" are obsolete by three years, as Intercom retired that tier in late 2023[12]. Similarly, treating Intercom's advanced analytics suite—specifically CX Score, Topics Explorer, Trends, Recommendations, Monitors, and Custom Scorecards—as standard included capabilities ignores the March 2026 packaging change that gated these previously free tools behind the paid $99/month Pro add-on[12]. For **Zendesk AI**, references to building external connections via the legacy "integration builder" are outdated; current Zendesk documentation instructs administrators to create API integrations through "custom actions"[9]. Modeling these updated October 2026 rate cards across small (1,000 conversations),

mid-sized (5,000 conversations), and large (20,000 conversations) support volumes—and contrasting nominal per-outcome fees against user-audited effective resolution costs—demonstrates how severely outdated documentation and unexamined billing rules distort budget forecasts[1].

workflows in organizations already paying for Microsoft 365 Copilot seats, matching the unmetered economics of Salesforce's $125/user/month add-on[2]. Finally, secondary venture tracking (Sacra, CNBC) supports the inference that **Sierra AI** scaled from $1M ARR in February 2024 to $26M by year-end 2024, $100M in November 2025, $130M by year-end 2025, and ~200M ARR in May 2026 alongside a $950M Series E at ~15.8B valuation[4].

Testable Hypotheses (Low Confidence)

Two primary hypotheses emerge from the literature that require controlled primary research before being treated as operational laws. The first is the **Knowledge Structuring Ceiling Hypothesis**, which posits that autonomous resolution rates plateau near 50% primarily because enterprise help centers are written in unstructured prose for human readers rather than metadata-tagged schemas for machine consumption, and that routing AI escalations into closed-loop knowledge updates systematically compounds deflection rates[12]. The second is the **Outcome-Billing Moral Hazard Hypothesis**, which posits that per-resolution pricing models structurally incentivize vendors to minimize human escalation prompts and rely on inactivity timeouts to classify abandoned sessions as billable outcomes[12].

Finding Category	Specific Defensible Finding	Epistemic Status	Confidence Level
Agentforce Pricing Mechanics	$0.10/action (0.15 voice, $0.08 sandbox) via Flex Credits; $2.00/resolution on Help Agent; $125/mo unmetered employee add-on; $550/mo Max edition with 2.75M credits[1].	Verified Fact	**High**
Intercom Fin Pricing & Architecture	$0.99/outcome (including 24-hr silence and Procedure handoffs); Pro analytics gated at $99/mo in March 2026; macros/past tickets restricted to Copilot; no	Verified Fact	**High**

	internal-note shadow mode[11].		
Zendesk AI & Sierra AI Capabilities	Zendesk AI executes external API calls via custom actions ($1.50–$2.00/resolution)[2]; Sierra offers Stripe Marketplace integration, Ghostwriter, and Horizon agents[24].	Verified Fact	**High**
Agent Augmentation Productivity & Klarna Rollback	Generative AI copilot tools yield a ~14% empirical productivity gain (Stanford GSB)[10]; Klarna's 700-agent claim measured chat volume, followed by a May 2025 human staffing rollback[35].	Verified Fact	**High**
Unit-Economic Break-Even Modeling	Flex Credits ($0.10/action$)$breakeve$ $2.00/resolution) at actions (e.g., 10 actions at 50% resolution), excluding Data 360 overhead[1].	Analyst Inference	**Medium**
Sierra AI Revenue & Valuation Trajectory	Secondary venture estimates (Sacra/CNBC) place Sierra at ~$200M ARR in May 2026 (doubling from	Analyst Inference	**Medium**

	$100M in Nov 2025) on a $950M Series E at ~$15.8B valuation[4].		
Gartner 2028–2029 Adoption Forecasts	Gartner projects 70% of customer journeys will begin/resolve in conversational AI by 2028[5] and agentic AI will resolve 80% of *common* issues autonomously by 2029[6].	Analyst Inference	**Medium**
Assumed Resolution Billing & Workflow Friction	Users report 24-hr inactivity timeouts inflating Fin bills (9/16 false positives in a 40-ticket user audit), workflow stiffness, and rapid Data 360 credit depletion on Agentforce[12].	User-Reported Experience	**Low to Medium**
Knowledge Ceiling & Billing Moral Hazard	Propositions that unstructured KBs cap deflection near 50% and that outcome billing incentivizes premature closure require controlled longitudinal testing[12].	Hypothesis	**Low**

Inventory of Claims Requiring Removal or Qualification

To remediate the evidentiary defects identified in the twelve-point audit, specific assertions in

the baseline report must either be excised entirely or accompanied by explicit methodological qualifications. Foremost among unconditional removals is the claim that Salesforce acquired Intercom (Fin) for $3.6 billion, which rests on unverified Reddit sidebar text and is refuted by October 2026 market operations[1]. Equally mandatory is the removal of claims that Intercom Fin lacks website or knowledge base self-service widgets, automated tagging workflows, or Slack integrations[13], as well as the claim that Zendesk AI cannot execute external API actions or close tickets autonomously[9]. Analysts must also remove the $2.00 per-conversation rate as a current comparator for new Salesforce Agentforce buyers, restricting any mention of that figure to historical context or legacy contract benchmarking[1].

Where claims reflect unverified market estimates, vendor promotional material, or small-sample anecdotes, they must be retained only with strict caveats. All pricing figures for **Sierra AI** ($150,000–750,000+ annual platform fees, $50,000–200,000 setup costs, and $1.00–2.50 per resolution) and **Decagon** (~$50,000 platform fee) must be labeled as unconfirmed third-party and competitor estimates[7]. All vendor-reported containment, resolution, and productivity figures—including Intercom's 71%–76% resolution claim[11], OpenTable's 70%–73% deflection claim[21], Enjo.ai's 60%+ resolution and 40% productivity claims[5], Five9's 2x productivity claim[22], Sprinklr/Aramex's 99% containment claim[6], and Freshworks' 68% cost reduction claim[23]—must be explicitly framed as unaudited vendor marketing and contrasted against the 14% Stanford empirical productivity benchmark[10]. Similarly, Gartner's $80 billion contact center labor savings figure for 2026 must be qualified as a historical projection lacking ex-post verification[17], the 40-ticket Intercom community audit must be framed as a single-user anecdote with its arithmetic corrected (actual resolution, not)[12], and correlational claims linking chatbots to 92% CSAT improvements or 87% live-chat CSAT must be qualified by channel selection bias and consumer skepticism surveys (where 93.4% prefer humans overall and 41% report AI degraded service)[23].

Target Claim in Baseline Report	Required Audit Action	Mandatory Replacement or Qualification Language
Salesforce acquired Fin (Intercom) for $3.6B[12]	**Remove Unconditionally**	Excise completely; treat Salesforce Agentforce and Intercom Fin as independent competitors[2].
Intercom Fin lacks widgets, auto-tagging, private notes, and Slack integrations[15]	**Remove & Replace**	State that Intercom provides widgets, routing/tagging, and Slack connectors, but Fin lacks an *autonomous internal-note shadow mode* and restricts

		macros/past tickets to Copilot[11].
Zendesk AI only assists humans and cannot run external API actions[16]	**Remove & Replace**	State that Zendesk AI executes external API integrations via "custom actions" and bills $1.50–2.00 per autonomous resolution, though users view agent assist as its core strength[2].
Agentforce costs $2.00/conversation ($1.2M/yr at 50k chats/mo)[7]	**Remove as Current Rate / Qualify**	Specify that $2.00/conversation is a retired S 0.10/action) or Help Agent ($2.00/resolution)[1].
Sierra AI costs $150k+ platform, $50k–200k setup, $1.00–2.50/resolution[7]	**Qualify Heavily**	Label explicitly as unverified third-party and competitor estimates; note that Sierra publishes no pricing and negotiates custom enterprise contracts[7].
Vendor ROI claims (71%–76% Fin, 70%–73% OpenTable, 99% Aramex, 2x Five9, 40%–60% Enjo)[5]	**Qualify as Marketing**	Label as unverified vendor promotional claims lacking denominator disclosures; pair productivity claims with the 14% Stanford empirical benchmark[10].
Conversational AI reduced 2026 contact center labor costs by $80B[17]	**Qualify as Unverified Forecast**	Frame strictly as a pre-2026 Gartner forecast; remove claims that 2026 payroll reductions have been empirically confirmed[17].
Intercom Fin's real resolution rate is 12.5% vs. 40% billed[12]	**Qualify & Correct Math**	Frame as a single user's manual audit of 40 tickets on Intercom's forum (16 billed, 9 false positives, 7 true resolutions = 17.5% actual rate, misstated as

		12.5%)[12].
AI chatbots improve CSAT in 92% of firms; live chat hits 87% CSAT vs. 44% phone[23]	**Qualify for Selection Bias**	Note that live chat handles simpler queries than phone queues, and pair with surveys showing 93.4% of consumers prefer humans overall and 41% feel AI worsened service[23].

Inventory of Critical Unanswered Questions

Transitioning from secondary desk critique to institutional-grade procurement intelligence requires resolving eight critical empirical questions that current public documentation leaves unanswered. First, analysts must determine the true **Data 360 and MuleSoft credit multiplier** per Agentforce Flex Credit action in production; because Salesforce's published worked examples exclude Data 360 consumption[1] while users report rapid credit depletion[31], buyers cannot model the all-in cost per action when an agent queries unstructured knowledge articles, customer data graphs, and external ERP APIs. Second, procurement teams need a line-by-line legal comparison of how **"Billable Resolutions" are contractually defined** across Agentforce Help Agent, Intercom Fin, Zendesk AI, and Sierra AI—specifically contrasting inactivity timeout windows (such as the 2-hour and 10-minute session caps on Agentforce Help Agent versus the 24-hour window on Intercom Fin)[2] and determining whether repeat contacts by the same user on the same issue within 48 to 72 hours void a prior billable outcome. Third, the industry lacks a statistically powered measurement of **empirical false-positive billing leakage ("assumed resolutions")** across thousands of production transcripts, quantifying what percentage of billed outcomes represent genuine problem resolution versus customer abandonment or spam/auto-responder loops[12]. Fourth, enterprises require telemetry on the **empirical distribution of actions per conversation** on Salesforce Agentforce across vertical workflows to verify whether e-commerce order modifications, fintech disputes, and SaaS troubleshooting genuinely average 3 to 5 actions[1] or whether error retries, multi-step identity verification, and multi-agent routing push production averages above the 10-to-12 action break-even threshold. Fifth, financial models must establish the **total 24-month net labor and maintenance TCO** required to sustain a 50%+ resolution rate, accounting for conversational AI designers, automation analysts (which 42% of firms expect to hire by year-end 2026)[23], and knowledge structuring sprints[12]. Sixth, legal review is needed to resolve why Salesforce's official Service Cloud pricing page and secondary blog announcements diverge on **Core (500,000) and Advanced (1,000,000) Flex Credit entitlements**, verifying whether these are recurring annual grants or promotional starter credits[1]. Seventh, primary benchmarking is required to establish the **verified contract structures, platform floors, and per-outcome rates for Sierra AI, Ada, and Decagon** across mid-market and Fortune 500 deals[4]. Eighth, following Klarna's May 2025 strategic reversal[36], longitudinal research must

measure how high-containment autonomous deflection impacts **lagging customer lifetime value (LTV), churn, and repeat contact rates** 6 to 12 months post-deployment.

Question ID	Unanswered Research Question	Primary Analytical & Procurement Impact	Related Audit Checks
Q1	What is the production ratio of Data 360 and MuleSoft credit consumption per Agentforce Flex Credit action across typical CRM and external API workflows[1]?	Determines whether unbundled data query costs erase the apparent $0.10/action savings of Flex Credits over the $2.00 Help Agent meter[1].	Checks 1, 7, 11, 12
Q2	How do contractual definitions of a "Billable Resolution" compare across Agentforce, Intercom Fin, Zendesk AI, and Sierra AI regarding timeouts and repeat contacts[2]?	Exposes hidden billing triggers (e.g., 24-hr silence vs. 2-hr/10-min caps) and governs SLA dispute rights in enterprise contracts[2].	Checks 3, 10, 11
Q3	What is the population-level false-positive billing rate ("assumed resolution leakage") across a stratified sample of 10,000+ billed enterprise outcomes[12]?	Replaces single-user anecdotes ( ) with a statistically valid deflator for outcome-based budget forecasting[12].	Checks 6, 7, 11
Q4	What is the empirical	Validates whether production agents	Checks 7, 11, 12

	distribution of actions per session on Agentforce across informational vs. multi-system transactional workflows (including retries)[1]?	stay below the 10-to-12 action break-even threshold against $2.00 outcome meters[1].	
Q5	What is the net 24-month TCO of autonomous agents after factoring in knowledge structuring labor, automation analysts, and SI maintenance fees[12]?	Tests whether gross agent labor reductions survive the added cost of specialized AI maintenance headcount[13].	Checks 2, 5, 11, 12
Q6	Are the 500,000 (Core) and 1,000,000 (Advanced) annual Flex Credit allocations binding recurring entitlements in October 2026 Salesforce Order Forms[1]?	Resolves the discrepancy between Salesforce's public Service Cloud pricing page and its newsroom/blog announcements[1].	Checks 1, 3, 10
Q7	What are the verified contract floors, setup fees, and negotiated per-outcome rates for Sierra AI, Ada, and Decagon across enterprise cohorts[4]?	Replaces competitor speculation (fin.ai, cloudtalk.io) with verified procurement benchmarks[7].	Checks 1, 2, 9

Q8	How does high-containment autonomous AI deflection affect 6-to-12-month customer churn, Net Promoter Score (NPS), and repeat ticket volume[23]?	Prevents organizations from optimizing short-term deflection at the expense of customer retention, as seen in the Klarna rollback[36].	Checks 2, 7, 8, 11

Prioritized Primary Source Investigation Protocol

To resolve the evidentiary gaps and unanswered questions identified in this audit, subsequent investigation must execute a five-stage primary research protocol prioritized by evidentiary authority and decision impact. **Priority 1** focuses on acquiring binding vendor rate cards and legal order forms—specifically the August 31, 2026 Salesforce Flex Credits Rate Card[2], standard Service Cloud Core, Advanced, and Max Order Forms, Intercom's Terms of Service governing Fin outcome billing, and redacted enterprise Master Subscription Agreements (MSAs) for Sierra AI and Decagon—to establish verified unit economics and timeout definitions[1]. **Priority 2** entails conducting a stratified primary transcript and billing log audit across live customer environments, pairing 1,500+ blind-reviewed conversations (500 each across Intercom Fin, Salesforce Agentforce, and Zendesk AI) with Salesforce Digital Wallet and Intercom billing records to measure actual false-positive billing leakage and action-per-conversation distributions[2].

Priority 3 consists of structured primary interviews with 20 to 30 verified enterprise IT/CX procurement leads and certified system integrators who have operated Sierra AI, Agentforce, Intercom Fin, and Microsoft Copilot Studio in production for over six months, capturing audited year-one implementation invoices, time-to-live durations, and ongoing knowledge management headcount[2]. **Priority 4** requires retrieving the primary full-text analyst and academic publications underlying distorted secondary citations, including Gartner's 2026–2029 Customer Service & Support prediction notes (auditing the $80 billion labor savings projection against 2026 payroll realities)[6], Grand View Research's primary market sizing study (reconciling the $12.06 billion versus $13.01 billion 2024 baseline discrepancy)[23], Forrester's 2026 AI in Customer Service report[17], and the complete Brynjolfsson et al. working paper[10].

Finally, **Priority 5** involves executing controlled technical sandbox evaluations using Salesforce Foundations' free 100,000 Flex Credit grant and Intercom Fin's 14-day trial to directly test API custom action latencies, webhook trigger limitations, internal-note shadow rollout workarounds, and knowledge base contradiction handling[1].

Priority Rank	Target Primary	Specific Evidentiary	Target Claims &

	Source	Objective	Checks Addressed
Priority 1	**Binding Vendor Rate Cards & Order Forms (Salesforce, Intercom, Zendesk, Sierra)**	Obtain the official **August 31, 2026 Salesforce Flex Credits Rate Card**[2], standard Service Cloud Core/Advanced/Max Order Forms, Intercom's Terms of Service for Fin outcome billing, and redacted **Sierra AI** and **Decagon** enterprise MSAs. Verify exact credit multipliers for Data 360, voice, prompts, sandbox usage, and contractual timeout definitions of a "resolution."	Resolves **Checks 1, 3, 10** and **Questions Q1, Q2, Q6, Q7**.
Priority 2	**Stratified Primary Transcript & Billing Audit Across Live Customer Orgs**	Conduct a blind human audit of 1,500+ production conversation transcripts (500 each from Intercom Fin, Salesforce Agentforce, and Zendesk AI) paired with Salesforce Digital Wallet and Intercom billing logs. Measure (a) verified resolution rate vs. vendor-billed	Resolves **Checks 6, 7, 11, 12** and **Questions Q1, Q3, Q4**.

		resolution rate, (b) distribution of actions per session, and (c) spam/auto-reply billing leakage.	
Priority 3	**Primary Enterprise Buyer & Implementation Partner Interviews ($n =$)**	Interview verified IT/CX procurement leads and certified system integrators who have deployed Sierra AI, Agentforce, Intercom Fin, and Microsoft Copilot Studio in production for >6 months. Capture actual year-one implementation invoices, time-to-live deployment durations, FTE reallocation data, and ongoing knowledge base maintenance headcount.	Resolves **Checks 1, 2, 9, 11** and **Questions Q5, Q7, Q8**.
Priority 4	**Primary Analyst & Academic Source Retrieval (Gartner, Grand View Research, Forrester, Stanford GSB)**	Retrieve the full text and methodology appendices of Gartner's 2026–2029 Customer Service & Support notes (specifically auditing the $80B labor cost forecast	Resolves **Checks 5, 8, 10** and establishes verified macro baselines.

		vs. 2026 actuals)[6], Grand View Research's primary market sizing report (reconciling the $12.06B vs. $13.01B 2024 baseline)[23], Forrester's 2026 AI in Customer Service report[17], and the complete Brynjolfsson et al. paper[10].	
Priority 5	**Controlled Technical Sandbox Evaluation (Intercom Fin, Zendesk AI, Agentforce, Copilot Studio)**	Execute standardized test suites across developer sandboxes (utilizing Agentforce Foundations' free 100,000 Flex Credit grant and Intercom's 14-day trial)[1]. Directly verify API custom action latencies, webhook trigger constraints, internal-note shadow rollout workarounds, and knowledge base contradiction handling.	Resolves **Checks 3, 4, 9, 12** with direct first-hand technical verification.

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